



One for the future: Calm under pressure, Ashu Malik (in blue) maintains a stoic demeanour on the mat. However, when he raids, he transforms into a formidable force. PKL MEDIA

seasons of hard work, he was thrust into a leadership role when the team's talisman was sidelined for the year.

"Luck plays a significant role in not only sports but also every aspect of life. At some point, everyone relies on a bit of good fortune," opines Ashu.

Despite being only in his third season, Ashu was named stand-in captain by then Delhi coach Rambir

Singh Khokar.

He ended PKL 10 with 276 raid points from 228 successful raids. He also led the matrix in average raid points (12), do-or-die raid points (41), and super raids (9), which helped guide his team to the playoffs.

"There wasn't any pressure on me. The team was mostly young players. I was one of the more experienced members. Everyone was very supportive. The coach

helped us bounce back from our initial struggles, and we soon started to play with renewed confidence," explains the raider.

Ashu's fairytale journey didn't end there. After the PKL season, the 22-year-old played a pivotal role in helping Haryana clinch the Senior National Kabaddi Championship after over a decade. He was named Player of the Match in the final, where his 13 raid points guided Haryana to a narrow 34-31 victory over Railways.

Ashu defies the stereotype of a flamboyant raider. His understated approach coupled with a diverse skill set makes him a unique and effective player. But it's his uncanny ability to read the game that elevates him over the rest.

In Delhi's opening match of PKL 11 against U Mumba, Ashu executed a brilliant raid, scoring two points with a simple yet effective move. Targeting the left chain of the six-man Mumba defence, he cleverly kicked the joined hands of two defenders.

"Ashu has a very calm and mature head on his shoulders. His game awareness is beyond his years and it's always a sign of a good player and, more importantly, a leader," opines Delhi coach Joginder Narwal, who was also Ashu's first skipper in PKL.

Now a full-time PKL captain, Ashu explains how he adapts his team's approach according to match situations. "If we find ourselves trailing by a substantial margin, we shift our focus to tightening our defensive line and prolonging the match. As the game enters its final phase, we intensify our offensive tactics, employing aggressive raiding and defensive strategies."

As his PKL career flourishes, Ashu is driven to excel and ultimately secure a spot on the Indian team, aiming for Asian Games gold.

"The aim is to represent India. Winning the Asian Games gold for the country is the ultimate dream for any kabaddi player," concludes Ashu.

As PKL enters a new decade, kabaddi is advancing rapidly, with players like Ashu leading the way.